journey to Kanyakumari. I was travelling with a friend at the time who was not connected to politics. While we were on the road, I remember having a conversation with him about how this Yatra was constantly reminding him of Bapu's Dandi March. Our discussion made us realize how often history is in the making around us and we either don't realize it or don't get the opportunity to be part of it. I remember his contented smile when he said he was glad that he was going to witness and be part of something that might reflect in our history in times to come. I didn't say anything to him at the time, but the weight of his and others' expectations conferred a heavy responsibility on all of us.

Once we reached Kanyakumari, finding accommodation until the Yatra began was another big task, especially for my friend, who had not planned to come in advance. After much to and fro, my friends, a few select yatris and I finally managed to get accommodation in a government guest house. As we laughingly spoke about our travel until then and anticipations ahead, another friend, who had also registered to become a yatri, had planned well in advance and reached Kanyakumari well in time, shared how, despite all the planning, he had forgotten to get a raincoat. We all laughed, yet it became amply clear to us from the beginning that no matter how prepared we were, no matter what arrangements we had made, the Yatra would move at its own pace and would have its own challenges.

After a couple of nights filled with restless excitement, the inauguration day arrived. At the southernmost tip of India in Kanyakumari, on the banks of the Indian Ocean, in the middle of light rain, the colours of our Tiranga glowing against the grey water-laden sky opened the Bharat Jodo Yatra. The flag hoisting was followed by words of encouragement by the leaders. The Yatra was finally afoot, with the Congress Sewa Dal members wearing Gandhi topis and singing patriotic songs of love and unity with the Tiranga in their hands leading the way. Behind them were Bharat yatris, state yatris, Rahul Gandhi and a sea of people. While most of them were Congress supporters, karyakartas and leaders, several civil society groups and independent citizens who believed in the values of the Yatra and Rahul Gandhi's leadership had also joined in. Nevertheless, no matter what the